

Zoom in for the kill

Agent 001 goes lens hunting

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It was a cloudy Saturday – a welcome relief from the heat. The weather buoyed my soaring spirits as I quickened my step to the nearby Saket metro station. My mission was to shop for a medium telephoto for my Canon 7D. I'd bought a Canon EF-S 18-135, EF 50 f1.4 and Tamron 17-50 f2.8. I wanted a good quality lens, something that would last me many years of upgrade cycles. My needs were something to shoot close-ups, take basic bird and animal shots, as well as serve as a tight portrait lens. I needed image stabilisation. I also needed something that would focus fast. Since there was also a need for good quality photos, that meant shelling out for one of the higher-end lenses.

Whether you're upgrading from your kit lens or buying another one to compliment it, first decide what focal range you need. Buying an 18-200 lens won't cut it, for I have found that lenses with wider focal ranges offer poorer results – simple laws of physics at work here. For APS-C sensor cameras, anything between 15 mm and 80 mm is good for general shooting, while 100-300 mm can be considered as a telephoto range. Above 300 mm would be a super telephoto – suitable for wildlife and such. Primes are good for shooting in low light owing to their wider apertures and most primes offer better quality than a variable focal range that costs twice as much. The only minus is they lack versatility.

The first thing to do is decide your focal range and fix your budget. Do some research before visiting shops. Google reviews, product details etc. and shortlist one or two models. Then

look around your city. There are several places in larger cities where you can pick up good deals on second-hand lenses. Buying a second-hand body is a no-no, but a lens is something that will either work, or not – so there are less chances of getting duped. But don't be cheap – restrict second-hand forays to costlier, higher-end lenses. Cheaper ones like kit lenses aren't built well, and old stuff will wear faster.

Sigma and Tamron are two other popular brands that build lenses for Canon, Nikon and Sony. All these manufacturers will have lenses that compete in similar focal ranges. Obviously prices will vary – Canon and Nikon charge a premium for their lenses. One generic thing to look for is the presence of faster, silent drive systems – Canon



Nikon AF-S 24-120mm

calls this its USM, while Nikon calls it SWM but they work pretty much the same with faster focus (a huge boon) and quiet functioning (not so much). The second thing to look for is image stabilisation (IS). Though lens IS systems aren't as good as the ones featured on compact cameras, they do help you maintain at least a 2-stop shutter speed advantage – useful for handheld photography. Both,

faster motors and IS will cost you pretty penny, and the cost of these two features could double the price of a lens, but it's worth it. Those who shoot in studios will use tripods and can do without IS.

The best deal for a generic focal range lens I found was the Nikon 16-85 VR, available on the street for ₹36,000. The Canon equivalent, the EF-S 15-85 IS USM is a bit expensive at ₹54,000, and while

it's good, if you want quality, the Canon EF-S 17-55 f2.8 IS USM is better, costs marginally more, and has a fast fixed aperture of f2.8. If you want a cheaper fast aperture lens, and can do without IS, look for the Tamron 17-50 f2.8. There are two versions of this lens: an older non-IS version which reportedly gives better quality results at a cost of ₹21,000 or so, while the IS version costs 5,000 bucks more. Nikon also has a 17-55 f2.8, and its lens retails for around ₹73,000.

I visited a Canon lounge, but it doesn't allow trying lenses on one's camera. In areas like Chandni Chowk in Delhi, shopkeepers will carefully open a sealed lens and allow you to test it. A known dealer might also allow you to keep it for a day to decide. I saw Canon's 70-200 f2.8 IS USM available as second-hand for ₹55,000 (₹1,05,000 for brand new) – a great lens, but a bit too heavy for handheld work, plus I wasn't going to shoot much of indoors. Then I saw the 70-200 f4 IS USM and after trying found it perfect – it's light, focuses fast and is really well built. The non-IS model was available for ₹41,000 while the dealer wouldn't budge off ₹54,000 for the IS model. From reviews I read, the IS model is a bit better optically, and this really sealed the deal and my wallet. After an hour of bargaining, he included a nice Hoya 67mm neutral filter and settled for ₹54,000. And my kit was complete. **U**